Dear PETCO Love,

On behalf of Rescue Voiceless Joint Forces, I would like to extend our sincere appreciation for the time and care you have taken to review our grant request. We recognize the value of your consideration and the responsibility that comes with evaluating programs designed to strengthen communities and improve outcomes for animal welfare. Your willingness to review our proposal reflects a shared commitment to meaningful change and to advance solutions that address real challenges faced by animals, shelters, and the people who support them.

Our team remains deeply committed to reducing euthanization of animals through structured behavioral preparation, workforce development, and strong community partnerships. We believe that when organizations join forces with purpose and accountability, they can create pathways for animals to transition into permanent homes or provide comfort as therapy pet companions, while also strengthening the systems in our communities that support them. Your review of our proposal plays an important role in helping initiate and move this work forward.

We are grateful for your consideration and for the leadership you demonstrate in supporting initiatives that promote humane care and sustainable community impact for animals. Regardless of the outcome, we appreciate the time invested in understanding our mission and the effort behind this initiative. We look forward to the possibility of working together to expand opportunities for animals to live safer, stable, and purposeful lives within our communities.

Thank you again for your time, your service, and your dedication to advancing programs that make a lasting difference in animal welfare.

Respectfully,
Liz
Rescue Voiceless Joint Forces

Rescue Voiceless Joint Forces

Grant Proposal Request

Organization

Rescue Voiceless Joint Forces (RVJF) is a newly developed program that will unify multiple organizations in their efforts to reduce euthanization of dogs and cats from animal shelters. By linking animal rescue shelters, therapy programs, and community organizations, RVJF will ensure animals receive structured behavioral preparation that strengthens adoption success or expands therapy pet companionship opportunities. Our partnerships with longstanding, reputable organizations that agree with our mission to join forces have met together to review the pilot project and ensure it is structured for success. These partners bring experience, knowledge, and resources that strengthen the pilot project and support consistent care for animals from intake through placement.

The pilot project is designed to build lasting partnerships that promote accountability, collaboration, and meaningful impact. Through continued cooperation among shelters, trainers, and community organizations, RVJF is aligned with PETCO Love's mission of aiding in animal welfare by strengthening operations and supporting ongoing efforts to reduce euthanization at animal shelters in our communities. This coordinated effort helps improve placement success and creates stronger support systems for animal shelters and the communities they serve.

Statement of Need

While animals are surrendered or abandoned for many reasons, the lack of behavioral training limits opportunities for dogs and cats to be successfully placed in homes or serve meaningful purposes in our communities leading to significant causes of euthanization in animal shelters throughout San Antonio, TX. Based on national data from 2024 and 2025, well over 7,000 dogs and 5,000 cats were euthanized in the San Antonio Animal Care Services. Even though the San Antonio Animal Care Services are working toward high live-release rates, they still face behavioral barriers, overcrowding, and limited placement options, yet their euthanasia numbers are substantial despite current measures in place. Dogs and cats in animal shelters often become limited in where they can go because of how they behave under stress. Extended confinement in animal shelters can cause anxiety, withdrawal, or reactivity. These behaviors reduce adoption appeal, rehoming and restrict placement opportunities to potentially be a part of our communities. Through behavioral preparation and structured interaction, dogs and cats can build stability that increases their chances for successful permanent

adoption with a family or assist one of our most needed communities through therapy pet companionship to aid in reducing senior isolation.

The goal for this pilot project is designed to become a full-time model program that can be replicated in animal shelters with considerable numbers of euthanasia, giving them opportunities to live safer and more purposeful lives. The objective of the pilot project is to upskill structured behavioral training for employees, which leads to dogs and cats gaining improved broader placement potential or adaptability for therapy pet companionship within our senior community. These changes will lead to higher volunteer participation and expanding animal assistance into other communities. This initiative, led by RVJF, is imperative to save countless voiceless animal lives within our communities by aligning with the same lifesaving work PETCO promotes in animal welfare.

Work Plan

The pilot project will proceed in four phases over twelve months.

First, San Antonio Animal Care Services employees will become certified animal handlers with the assistance of the Texas State University Animal-Assisted Counseling Academy (AAC). Staff will complete structured training in low-stress handling, animal behavior recognition, positive reinforcement training methods, and therapy-readiness preparation. The goal is to fortify internal positions, so the rescue shelter does not rely solely on outside trainers. Second, dogs and cats will participate in structured training sessions focused on behavioral stability. Depending on the success of the behavioral training and evaluation process from Therapy Animals of San Antonio (TASA), dogs and cats will be placed into one of two outcome categories: adoption readiness for successful placement into permanent homes or therapy pet companionship for participation in structured therapy programs assisting seniors in assisted living facilities. Third, the pilot project will facilitate adoptions and therapy placements with extended volunteer support from Kim Hinze, Director of Community Engagement at the San Antonio Humane Society. The final phase will repeat the process, track outcomes, and document for grant renewal and program replication.

The pilot project will be evaluated and structured into a replicable model that can be implemented in other rescue shelters into other communities statewide and nationally.

History and Duration of the Project

RVJF is a newly created program to bring organizations together to work toward the same goal of improving outcomes for animals in shelters. By working as a unified team, partners can share responsibilities, support staff and volunteers, and provide structured behavioral preparation that increases adoption readiness and expands therapy pet companionship opportunities to reduce isolation amongst seniors at senior centers. San Antonio animal rescue shelters have expanded facilities and veterinary services in recent years. However, opportunities remain to innovate within intake, care, and adoption pipelines to reduce euthanasia rates. This pilot project introduces a structured behavioral framework that prepares dogs and cats for successful placement through adoption or therapy pet companionship, addressing limitations in the current rescue center structure where animals are frequently rehomed or returned due to challenges adjusting to their new homes. Rather than relying solely on housing and adoption availability, animals receive structured preparation that increases permanent placement opportunities. The pilot project duration is twelve months and is structured into four implementation phases, making it measurable, scalable, and replicable for other humane societies seeking to align with PETCO's lifesaving animal welfare mission.

Timeline

Time	Tasks	Reviews
Phase 1 3 months	Upskill employees to become handlers Separate dogs and cats that are ready for training Facility updates and make preparations for program launch Launch social media campaigns to build community awareness	Monthly evaluations to monitor readiness and progress from employees and animals
Phase 2 6 months	Employees become certified animal handlers Dogs and cats become certified as adoption-ready or therapy pet companions Reevaluate program challenges and identify pain points	Mid-year evaluations to measure progress Conduct progress surveys to gather feedback
Phase 3 9 Months	Develop progressive reports on program outcomes Share social media success stories highlighting placements and therapy support	Continue monthly evaluations to track performance

	Expand outreach to community partners and volunteers	Conduct progress surveys to monitor improvements
Phase 4 12 months	Document ongoing pilot project results and measurable outcomes Conduct an overall review of pilot project performance Prepare final results to support new grant opportunities Process final reporting results to transition to model program	Complete end-of-year evaluations Conduct final surveys to assess program impact and sustainability

Budget

The overall projected cost for the pilot project directed by RVJF, is $500,000, with $300,000 requested from Petco Love to support key initiatives at San Antonio Animal Care Services. The requested funds will be allocated across workforce development, wage increases, project improvements, animal behavioral training, project evaluations and resources to support community partnerships. Initiating the pilot project, begins with a workforce development to train 30 employees with upskill certifications for each employee $600 totaling in the amount of $20,000. Once employees have completed their training, the annual salary will be increased by $5,000 totaling $150,000 as bonuses or honoraria. The program improvements, such as hiring a program coordinator, facility supplies, and materials to uphold evaluations throughout the pilot project period, is valued at $70,000. After employees are trained, they will certify dogs and cats at $150 each for behavioral training using training equipment, handling materials, and ensure animal welfare supplies that will enhance care outcomes are budgeted at $35,000, while $15,000 will fund adoption placement costs, crisis placement assistance, transportation to senior centers for pet therapy, events at school or in communities, and related pilot project materials. To secure operational effectiveness, $5,000 will be invested in technology for data tracking, surveys, reporting, and social media outreach to increase community engagement for therapy pet companionships and adoption visibility. The remaining $5,000 will cover miscellaneous supplies and materials necessary for daily operations during the proposed grant 12 month period.

Staff

Texas State University – AAC Academy will provide professional guidance in developing employee competency in animal-assisted intervention frameworks.

Kim Hinze, Director of *Community Engagement at the San Antonio Humane Society*, will assist in strengthening volunteer coordination and outreach relationships that support behavioral programming and community integration.

Therapy Animals of San Antonio (TASA) will provide expertise and outline guidelines for employee handlers to train animals successfully for therapy pet companionship.

Stephanie Mercado will serve as the primary contact for dog and cat therapy programs and classes at the *Granados Adult & Senior Center*, where therapy animals will support seniors experiencing isolation.

Program Coordinator, oversees the entire pilot project daily operations, maintains communication among partner organizations, and ensures program activities are implemented as planned.

Each partner contributes to a defined role, creating a collaborative model that strengthens animals, staff, and long-term program scalability.

Sustainability Plan

After the pilot project completes the twelve months and transitions to a model program, RVJF will be sustained through continued funding and community partnerships that support daily operations and project growth. Our collaboration with experienced professionals, each working in their defined roles, creates a strong operational foundation, accountability, and lasting project stability to advance its execution. This coordinated approach allows the model program to remain effective while adapting to the evolving needs of shelters, animals, and the communities they serve.

Local pet store partnerships will provide on-site supply booths at San Antonio Animal Care Services for direct access to essential resources for adoptions while increasing public visibility and community engagement. Adoption fees and therapy program participation will generate supplemental revenue that supports animal care, training materials, and program coordination. RVJF will also host an annual fundraising Pet Walk with Pet Partners and similar community-based events that encourage volunteer participation, strengthen public awareness, and build reliable financial support from donors and sponsors committed to animal welfare.

To ensure lasting sustainability for the model program, RVJF will continue pursuing grant opportunities, corporate sponsorships, and collaborative partnerships that align with the program’s mission to reduce euthanization and expand placement

pathways for dogs and cats. Pilot project data, outcome tracking, and documented success stories will be used to demonstrate measurable impact and strengthen future funding requests. Through responsible planning, consistent evaluation, and strong community relationships, RVJF will maintain a stable model program structure capable of operating beyond the pilot period and serving as a replicable model for other shelters seeking to improve animal welfare outcomes.

Through PETCO's support and continued community investment, RVJF will demonstrate how structured workforce development, animal behavioral preparation, and coordinated community partnerships can strengthen humane society operations to reduce euthanization while creating lasting, measurable improvements for animals and the communities they live in.

Plan of Evaluation

The evaluation of the RVJF pilot project will be structured to measure clear, practical outcomes that reflect both immediate progress and long-term impact on animal welfare and community engagement. Data will be collected consistently throughout the twelve-month implementation period to monitor improvements in behavioral readiness, adoption success, and therapy pet placement outcomes for dogs and cats from participating senior centers in the program. Monthly evaluations will allow staff to identify barriers early, address operational challenges, and adjust training approaches to ensure animals are receiving the support needed to improve stability and placement potential.

Project staff and certified handlers will document behavioral progress using standardized observation tools, tracking indicators such as reduced stress behaviors, improved social interaction, and successful transition into adoption-ready or therapy-certified status. Adoption and therapy placement rates will be reviewed alongside a program coordinator, volunteer participation levels, and community outreach engagement to determine how effectively the pilot project strengthens animal shelter operations and expands placement opportunities. Surveys and feedback collected from staff, volunteers, partner organizations, and participating facilities will provide additional insight into pilot project effectiveness and highlight areas for continued improvement.

The results gathered throughout the pilot phases will be compiled into structured progress reports at mid-year and at the conclusion of the scheduled twelve months. These findings will guide the operation for pilot project refinement, sustainability planning, and replication in other animal shelters facing similar euthanization challenges. By documenting measurable outcomes and lessons learned, RVJF will

ensure the pilot project remains accountable, scalable, and aligned with the broader mission transition into a model program of reducing euthanization while creating stronger pathways for animals to live safe, stable, and purposeful lives within their communities.